

Who Leaves Teaching, and Why?

The Anatomy of Teacher Attrition in the United States, 2005–2024

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Abstract

Roughly 8 percent of American teachers leave the profession each year, a rate that has barely moved since the early 1990s—yet almost everything policy-relevant about that number lies in a decomposition that existing work does not provide. Using two decades of Current Population Survey March supplements (2005–2024), I document not just how many teachers leave but who they are, where they go, and what the move costs them. Of every 100 leavers, 62 exit the labor force altogether—38 at retirement ages, 24 before 55—12 become unemployed, and only 26 hold another job a year later, a fifth of those still inside education. Leaving is predicted by the shape of the job, not the person: teaching part of the year or part-time dominates every demographic trait, and pension coverage locks teachers in. The family margin is the exception, and it is distinctively large in teaching: a new baby raises a female teacher’s probability of leaving by 5.9 percentage points, two to three times the effect in nursing, accounting, or law. For those who do move to another job, leaving is a gamble rather than a raise: the median switcher gains 15 log points, but the tenth percentile loses 85, and nearly half of all leavers report no earnings at all the following year. Measured identically, teachers leave at the nurse benchmark, five points below social workers, and the ordering has not changed in thirty years. An appendix validates the retrospective instrument person-by-person against a linked monthly panel built from the raw CPS files—the first such audit in this literature—and a second appendix replicates Harris and Adams (2007) on the modern decades.

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1. Introduction

Teachers are the main school input in the production of student achievement (Rivkin, Hanushek and Kain, 2005; Chetty, Friedman and Rockoff, 2014), and replacing one is costly and disruptive for the students left behind (Ingersoll, 2001; Ronfeldt, Loeb and Wyckoff, 2013). Whether teachers are abandoning the profession, and which ones, is accordingly a perennial question of education policy—and one where the public debate runs well ahead of the data. Announcements of a post-pandemic exodus coexist with federal statistics showing single-digit attrition; a rich descriptive literature reports turnover levels but stops, almost uniformly, at the schoolhouse door, without following the leaver into her next job, her next paycheck, or her reasons.

The data to go further have existed, in public form, for decades. The March supplement of the Current Population Survey asks every adult two questions that bracket a teacher's exit: the occupation of the longest job held last calendar year, and what she is doing in the survey week. Harris and Adams (2007) used this instrument to establish the level of teacher attrition for 1992–2001 and to benchmark it against nurses, social workers, and accountants; Aldeman and Yi (2025) recently updated the same calculation to argue that turnover remains low. On the survey side, the National Center for Education Statistics measures leavers and movers with the Teacher Follow-up and National Teacher and Principal Surveys, the basis of the widely cited Learning Policy Institute syntheses (Carver-Thomas and Darling-Hammond, 2017; Tan, Wei, Carver-Thomas and García, 2024) and of Ingersoll's (2001) influential organizational account. What none of this work provides is an anatomy: the level is measured, sometimes compared, but the composition of exit—its routes, its destinations, its earnings consequences, its family triggers—remains largely unexamined in nationally representative data. The one administrative exception, Brummet, Penner, Pharris-Ciurej and Porter (2025), links teachers to tax records and finds that leavers rarely out-earn their classroom selves, but cannot observe household structure or compare professions.

This paper provides that anatomy, on the same public instrument the literature already trusts for the level, extended in every direction the instrument allows. Three features distinguish the exercise. First, *depth*: beyond the annual rate, I decompose every exit into its route (another job, unemployment, labor-force exit), its destination occupation, and—by linking consecutive March supplements at the person level—its earnings consequence, and I estimate the individual predictors of leaving including a family margin (births, young children) that the NCES surveys and the prior CPS literature do not model. Second, *time*: every result is computed as a comparison across periods, from 2005–2009 through the pandemic to 2024, anchored against Harris and Adams's 1992–2001 benchmarks, so that claims about “rising” attrition face thirty years of evidence measured with one ruler. Third, *measurement discipline*: because the CPS also permits linking the same person across monthly interviews, I build that panel from the raw files—twenty entry cohorts, 2005–2024—and audit the retrospective instrument person by person, the first individual-level validation of the measure on which this literature rests (Appendix A). The audit explains, observation by observation, why naive point-in-time panels overstate attrition by a factor of two or more, and why the retrospective anchor is the right instrument for the question.

The findings reorganize the usual conversation. The level is unremarkable and stable: 8.3 percent of college-graduate K–12 teachers leave per year in 2015–2024, against 7.7 in Harris and Adams's 1992–2001 and 9.1 in 2010–2014; the pandemic produced a spike to 10.2 percent measured in March 2020 and full reversion within two years, the same conclusion Aldeman and Yi (2025) reach. Teaching sits exactly at the nurse benchmark (8.0 percent), five points below social work, and the professional ordering is unchanged in three decades. But the composition is nothing like the popular image of teachers recruited

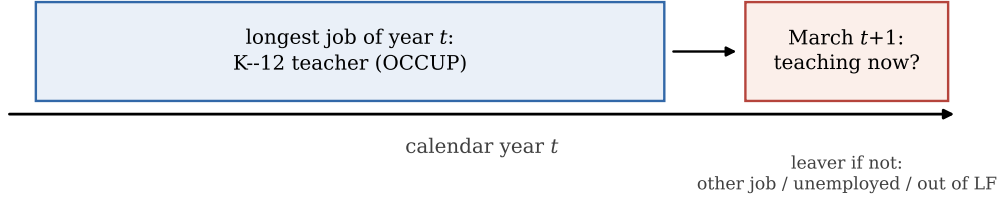


Figure 1: The retrospective instrument.

Each March, the ASEC records the occupation of the longest job held in the previous calendar year and the person’s current activity. A teacher in year t who is not teaching in March $t+1$ is a leaver, routed to another occupation, unemployment, or out of the labor force.

away by better-paying industries. Of every 100 leavers, 62 leave employment altogether and only 26 hold another job a year later—five of them in education-adjacent work. The strongest predictors of leaving are part-year and part-time attachment and the absence of a pension, not demographics; the exception is a new baby, whose effect on female teachers (+5.9 percentage points) is two to three times its size in any comparison profession—teaching loses mothers at a rate nursing does not. And for the minority who do switch jobs, the move is a lottery: a median gain of 15 log points wrapped in enormous dispersion, with nearly half of all leavers reporting zero earnings the following year. Attrition in teaching is not an exodus; it is retirement, family, and loose attachment, in that order.

2. Data and definitions

The data are the public-use person files of the CPS Annual Social and Economic Supplement (ASEC) for survey years 2006–2025, downloaded from the Census Bureau: CSV files from 2019 onward, fixed-width files parsed against the published data dictionaries for 2011–2018, and, for 2006–2010, extracted with byte positions recovered empirically and validated against the person identifiers of the March basic monthly files (Appendix A describes the method). Survey year $t+1$ measures attrition for calendar year t ; the supplements cover calendar 2005–2024. The main analytical window is 2015–2024, with 2010–2014 and Harris and Adams’s 1992–2001 as standing comparisons; the 2005–2009 files support the rate series only.

A person is a **teacher** in year t if the occupation of her longest job that year is K–12 classroom teaching: preschool and kindergarten, elementary and middle school, secondary school, special education, or teachers not elsewhere classified (census codes 2300–2330 plus 2340 under the 2002/2010 classifications and 2360 under the 2018 one; the core codes are identical across all three). Postsecondary teachers and teaching assistants are excluded, and the main sample is restricted to college graduates, both following [Harris and Adams \(2007\)](#). She is a **leaver** if in the following March she is no longer teaching, with the route read from the labor-force recode: employed in another occupation, unemployed, or out of the labor force. Employment status must come from the labor-force status variable rather than the occupation field, because the unemployed report their last job’s occupation—ignoring this counts displaced teachers as stayers. The measure captures leavers only; teachers who change school or district remain teachers here, so these rates sit below “total turnover” figures that add movers ([Ingersoll, 2001](#); [Tan et al., 2024](#) report

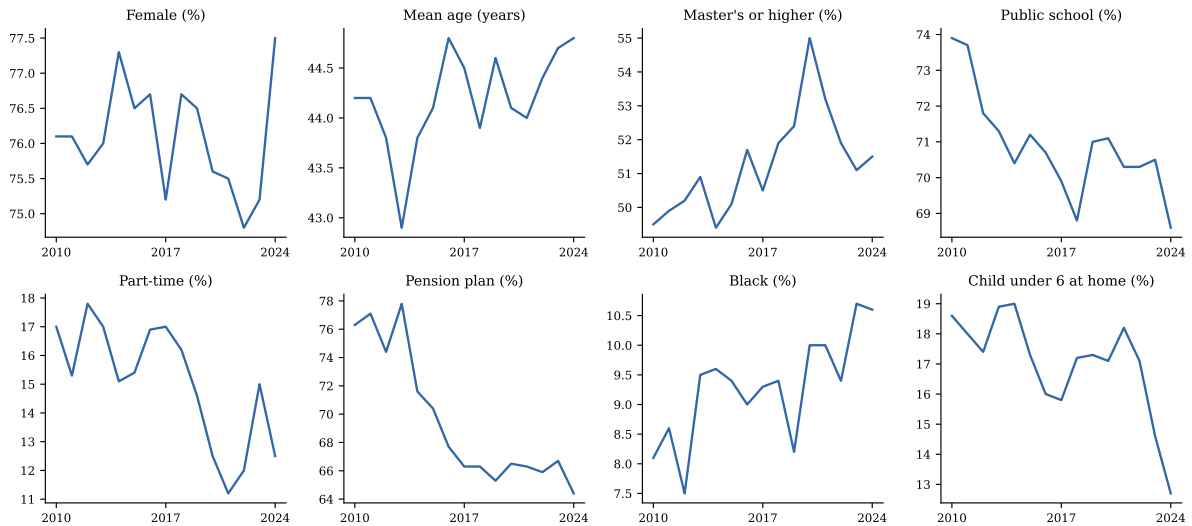


Figure 2: The changing profile of the teaching workforce.

College-graduate K–12 teachers (longest job of the calendar year), ASEC 2011–2025 = calendar 2010–2024, weighted. The 2013 point uses the reduced five-eighths 2014 file.

16 percent total turnover of which roughly half is moving). Own children, including births, are attached to each adult through the household parent and spouse pointers. All statistics use supplement weights.

3. Who teaches

The workforce against which attrition plays out has been drifting in quiet but consistent directions. Teaching remains three-quarters female and increasingly credentialed—the share with a master’s degree or more hovers above half—while the public-sector share has slipped and part-time teaching has become slightly more common. Pension coverage, teaching’s signature amenity, remains near seventy percent but is eroding at the margin. The workforce is not aging on average, a composition effect worth keeping in mind below: high attrition at retirement ages continuously removes the old, while entry replenishes the young.

4. How many leave

Pooled over 2015–2024, **8.25 percent** of college-graduate teachers leave the profession per year. The series wears its history lightly: 8–9 percent in the early 2010s, 7.3–8.7 in the late 2010s, a spike to **10.2 percent** for calendar 2019—measured in the March 2020 interviews, the first weeks of Covid—9.0 for calendar 2020, and full reversion by 2021 (7.1), holding through 2024 (7.7). Against Harris and Adams’s 7.7 percent for 1992–2001, the conclusion is stark: *three decades of alarm about accelerating teacher flight are not visible in the only long series measured with a constant instrument*. The pandemic registered as a two-year disturbance, exactly as [Aldeman and Yi \(2025\)](#) conclude, and as the NCES data ultimately showed (8.4 percent of 2020–21 teachers left before the next school year). Within the average, the familiar structure: public-school teachers leave at 6.8 percent, private-school teachers at 11.6—the same two-to-one ratio as in the TFS administrative benchmarks—and men slightly exceed women (9.1 versus 8.0).

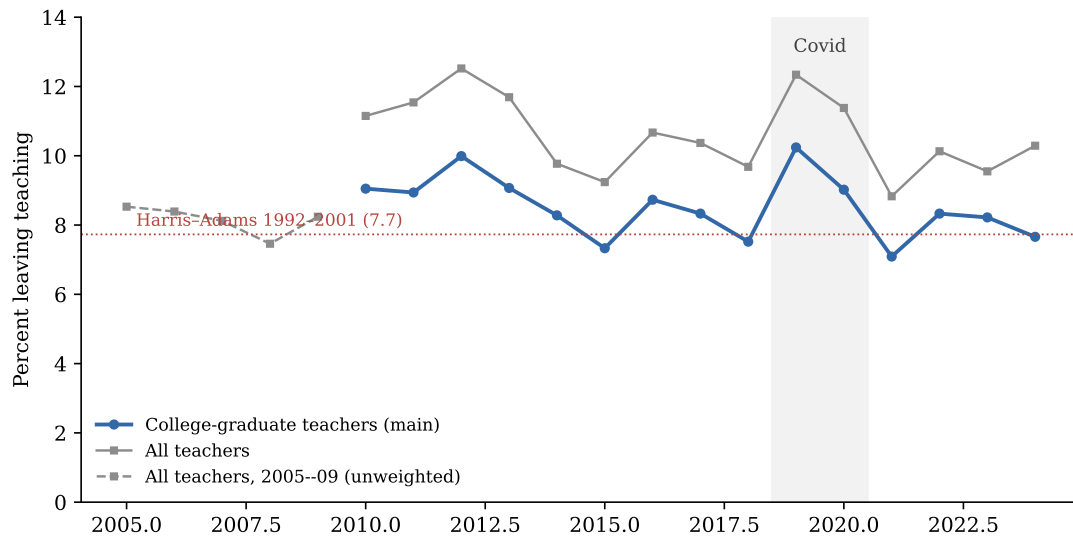


Figure 3: Attrition by year, against a thirty-year anchor.

Share of teachers (longest job of the calendar year) not teaching the following March. Solid blue: college graduates (main definition). Gray: all teachers regardless of degree. Dashed segment: 2005–2009, unweighted counts from the minimal early extraction. The dotted line marks Harris and Adams’s (2007) 7.73 percent for 1992–2001 under the identical design.

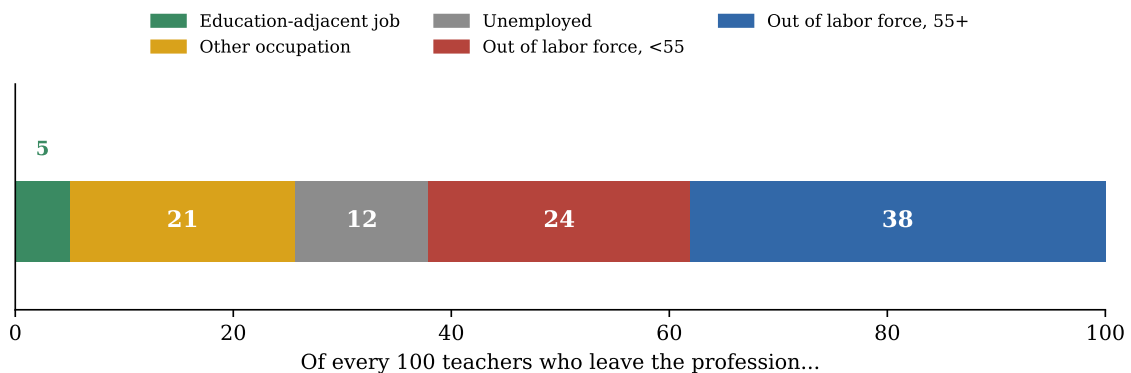


Figure 4: Of every 100 leavers.

Destinations in the March following the last teaching year, college-graduate teachers pooled 2015–2024, weighted. Education-adjacent: employed in occupations 2200–2555 (postsecondary, tutors, assistants, administrators, librarians).

5. Where they go

The single most policy-relevant fact in this paper is the destination split. Of every 100 leavers, **62 are not employed at all** a year later: 38 have left the labor force at ages 55 and above—the retirement channel—and 24 have left it younger, the margin where family (Section 6) lives. Twelve are unemployed. Only **26 hold another job**, and five of those remain in education-adjacent work: postsecondary teaching, tutoring, school administration, teaching assistance. The occupational destinations of the remaining switchers are managerial and administrative far more often than technical, echoing in survey data what [Brummet et al. \(2025\)](#) find in tax records. The popular narrative of attrition—teachers poached by higher-paying industries—describes at most a fifth of actual exits.

The routes are organized by age with almost mechanical clarity. Job-switching is a young teacher’s exit:

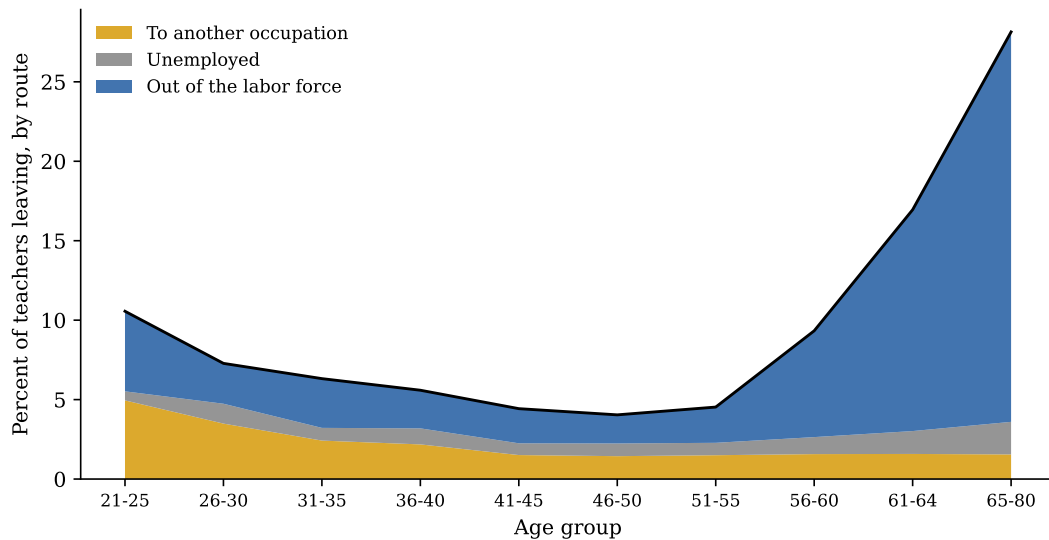


Figure 5: Exit routes over the lifecycle.

Share of teachers leaving by each route, by age group, pooled 2015–2024. The black line is total attrition; shaded areas stack the three routes.

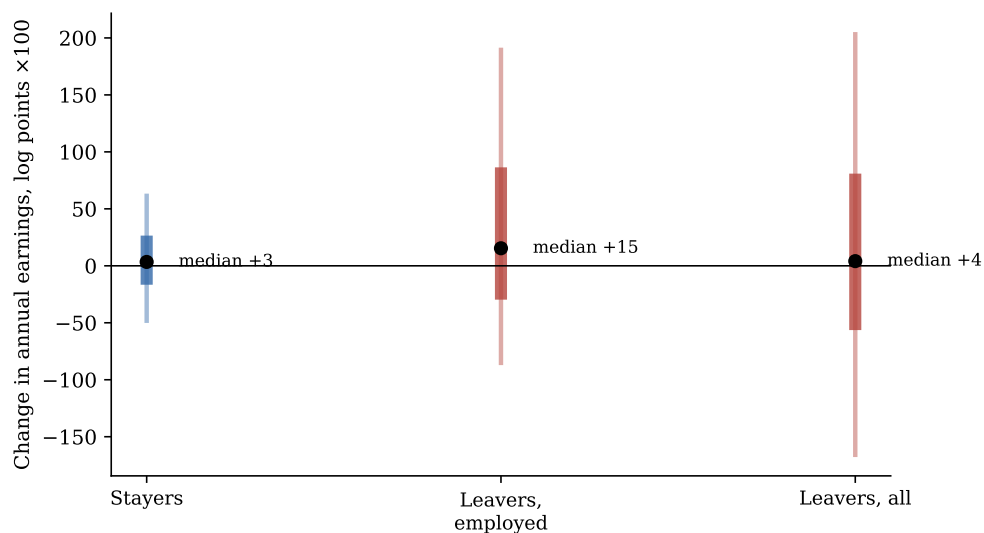


Figure 6: The earnings gamble of leaving.

Change in annual wage and salary earnings, log points $\times 100$, from the last teaching year to the following calendar year, for teachers linked across consecutive March supplements by person identifier (validated on sex and age progression), surveys 2011–2025. Thick bars: interquartile range; thin bars: 10th–90th percentiles; dots: medians. Among all leavers, 47 percent report zero earnings in the following year (excluded from the log-change distribution).

it peaks in the twenties and declines monotonically. Labor-force exit is the mirror image, modest through mid-career and exploding after 55; by ages 61–64 attrition is 17 percent, three quarters of it out of employment altogether. The trough in one’s forties—total attrition near 4 percent—identifies the tenured core of the profession. This U-shape, documented for the 1990s by [Grissmer and Kirby \(1997\)](#) and visible in Harris and Adams’s data, survives intact in the modern decades.

Linking the same person across consecutive Marches prices the move. For stayers, the earnings distribution does what salary schedules promise: a median gain of 3 log points inside a tight band. For leavers who hold a job, the median gain is larger—15 log points—but the band explodes: the 75th percentile

Table 1: Teachers who stay versus teachers who leave.

	Stayers	Leavers	Difference
Age, years	43.9	50.1	6.2
Female	76.2%	73.4%	-2.8%
Black	9.5%	10.8%	1.3%
Married	67.1%	63.7%	-3.3%
Separated or divorced	10.2%	11.7%	1.5%
Master's degree or higher	52.4%	45.8%	-6.6%
Public school	71.3%	58.0%	-13.3%
Enrolled in a pension plan	68.0%	51.2%	-16.8%
Part-time (<35 h/week)	11.9%	41.4%	29.5%
Worked full year (50+ weeks)	75.6%	31.3%	-44.3%
Weekly earnings (\$)	1177.4	1075.0	-102.4

Weighted means, college-graduate teachers pooled 2015–2024, measured in the teaching year. Earnings are annual wage and salary divided by weeks worked.

gains 81 log points while the 10th percentile *loses* 85. And this is the distribution conditional on earning anything: **47 percent of all leavers report zero earnings** in the year after leaving. Leaving teaching for work is a gamble that pays for the median mover and costs heavily in the tails; leaving teaching at all is, for nearly half of leavers, a transition into no earnings whatsoever—retirement, caregiving, or a gap year the CPS cannot distinguish further. The “earnings penalty of staying” that motivates much salary policy is nowhere visible in these transitions.

6. Who leaves, and why

The leaver, photographed during her last teaching year, differs from the stayer mainly in her contract, not her demography. She is six years older on average (the retirement tail), somewhat less likely to be in a public school and to hold a pension, and dramatically less attached: 41 percent of leavers taught part-time (against 12 percent of stayers) and only 31 percent worked a full 50-week year (against 76). Earnings while teaching were about nine percent lower. Race, marriage, and degrees move the comparison by a few points at most.

Multivariately, the ranking is unambiguous. Full-year work is worth -9.3 percentage points of exit risk, part-time $+4.5$, pension enrollment -2.4 , public school -1.7 : the attachment variables and the deferred-compensation lock, in that order, dwarf everything demographic. The pension coefficient echoes, at modern magnitudes, the job-lock Harris and Adams estimated for the 1990s, and it remains two to three times larger for teachers than for any comparison profession (Appendix B)—the fingerprint of a profession whose exits are choreographed by retirement systems rather than by outside offers.

The exception to “demographics don’t matter” is the family. A birth during the year raises a female teacher’s probability of leaving by **5.9 percentage points** (Figure 9), conditional on age, education, marriage, and other children—an effect on the order of the entire baseline attrition rate. The same specification estimated on women in comparison professions yields $+2.6$ points for nurses, $+3.5$ for accountants, $+2.4$ for lawyers, $+2.2$ for social workers: positive everywhere, as one expects around childbirth, but *two to three times larger in teaching*. Whatever combination of parental-leave provision, schedule rigidity during the school year, and household specialization produces this gap, teaching loses new mothers at a rate

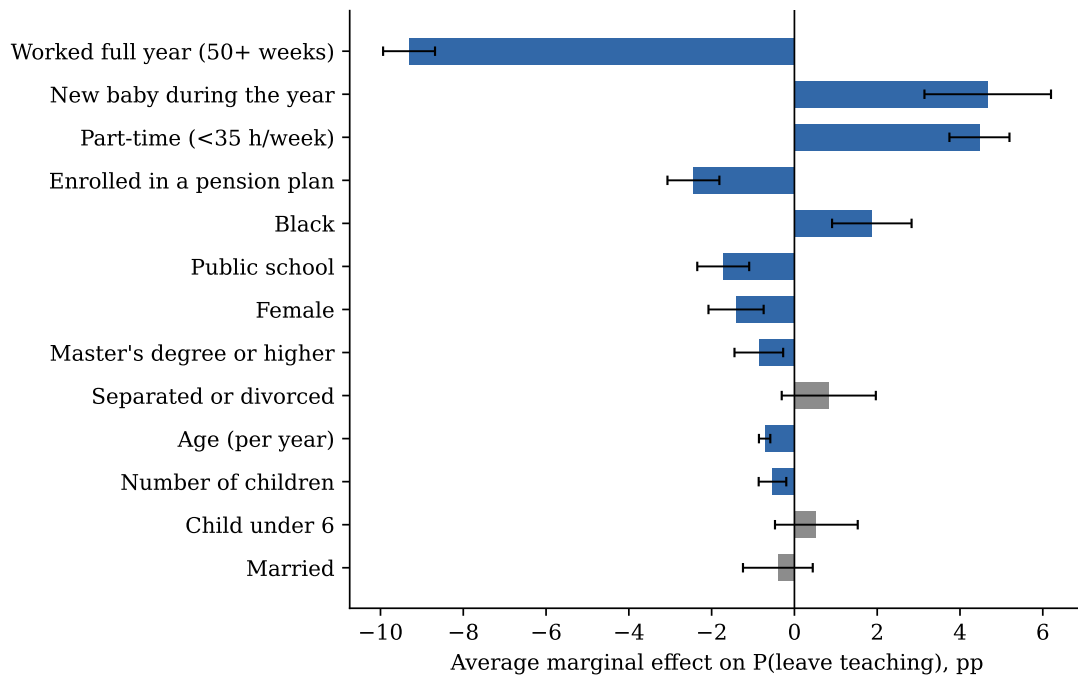


Figure 7: What predicts leaving.

Average marginal effects from a probit of leaving on characteristics of the teaching year, with survey-year fixed effects; college-graduate teachers pooled 2015–2024. Whiskers: 95 percent confidence intervals; gray: not significant at 5 percent. Age enters quadratically; its profile is in Figure 5.

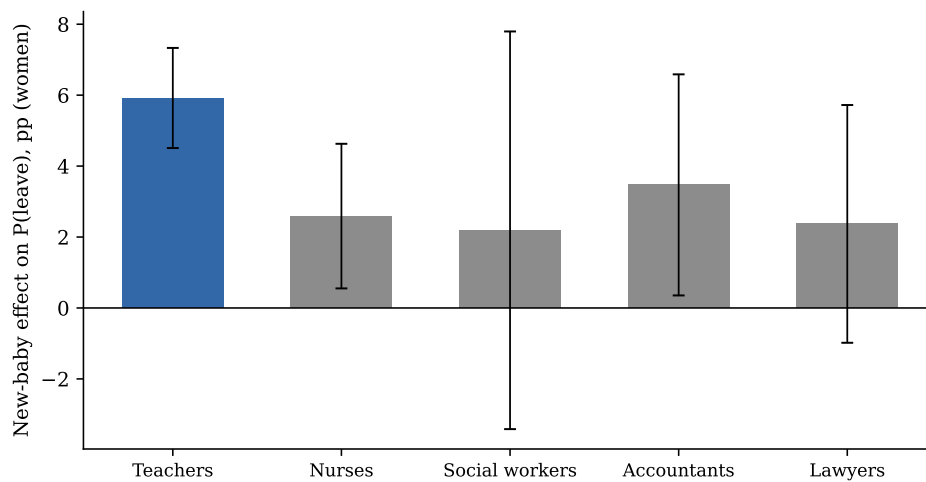


Figure 8: A new baby and the probability that a woman leaves her profession.

Average marginal effect of a child under one in the household, from profession-specific probits on women (age quadratic, marriage, advanced degree, other children controls), pooled 2010–2024. Whiskers: 95 percent confidence intervals.

its semi-professional peers do not, and no amount of aggregate-level reassurance about “normal” attrition addresses it.

Table 2: The top-risk decile.

	Top-risk decile	All teachers
Age	54.4	44.4
Female %	74.4	76.0
Part-time %	75.0	14.3
Full-year %	4.3	71.9
Pension %	35.6	66.6
Public %	45.2	70.2
Actual leaver rate %	33.0	8.2

Teachers in the top decile of predicted exit probability from the probit of Figure 7, versus all teachers. The model's risk concentrates in part-year, part-time, uncovered contracts; its realized attrition validates the ranking.

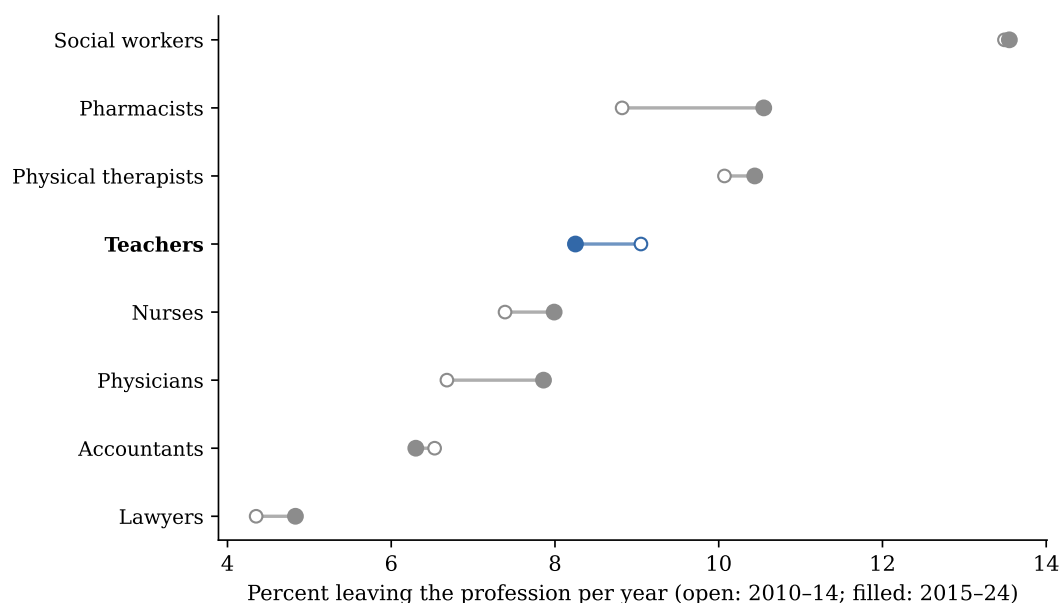


Figure 9: Leaving the profession, eight professions, two periods.

Annual profession-leaving rates under the identical instrument, college graduates: open circles 2010–2014, filled 2015–2024. Profession defined by the longest job of the calendar year; leaving includes unemployment and labor-force exit.

7. Teaching among the professions

Is 8 percent a lot? Measured with the same ruler, teachers leave teaching at almost exactly the rate registered nurses leave nursing (8.0), below physical therapists (10.4) and pharmacists (10.6), five points below social workers (13.6), and above accountants (6.3) and lawyers (4.8). The ordering is essentially Harris and Adams's, a generation later; the two periods shown differ by less than a point for most professions. Teaching's true distinctions are compositional: a larger share of its attrition exits the labor force (62 percent, versus 44 for nurses and 21 for social workers), its pension lock is stronger, and its family margin is larger. Teaching does not have an attrition problem relative to its peers; it has a *retirement system* and a *motherhood penalty* that shape when and how its attrition happens.

8. What it means for policy

Three lessons follow from the anatomy rather than the level. First, the aggregate rate is the wrong target: it has been flat for thirty years, sits at the nurse benchmark, and its pandemic excursion self-corrected. Retention policy motivated by a supposed exodus is aiming at a ghost. Second, the actionable margins are visible and specific: part-year and part-time attachments carry many times the exit risk of any demographic group; pension coverage retains; and the family channel—a five-point exit effect of a birth, unmatched in comparable professions—points directly at leave policy and within-year schedule flexibility as the binding constraints on retaining young mothers. Third, the destination evidence disciplines the rhetoric of competition: schools are not losing teachers to industry in any volume; they are losing them to retirement, to family, and to nothing at all. For the minority who do move, the move is a high-variance gamble, not a raise—which suggests the outside option constrains teacher retention far less than the inside conditions do.

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Appendix A. Validating the instrument person by person

Because the CPS interviews each address in four consecutive months, rests it for eight, and interviews it again in the same four calendar months a year later, individuals can be linked across interviews (Madrian and Lefgren, 2000) and teacher attrition can, in principle, be measured prospectively. We built this panel from the raw monthly files—twenty entry cohorts, 2005–2024—keeping the unambiguous teachers (employed in K–12 teaching in all four initial interviews) and defining a panel-leaver as one who teaches in none of the four follow-up interviews. For the subsample whose initial window includes March, the same person also answered the following year’s ASEC retrospective questions, and the two instruments can be cross-tabulated individual by individual. The same person identifiers link the supplement to the monthly files; for supplement years whose fixed-width layouts predate the published dictionaries, byte positions were recovered by scanning for the offset at which the 22-character person identifier reproduces the March monthly identifiers—a join that cannot succeed by accident—and validated on occupation agreement in the interview week.

Table 3: Panel classification versus March retrospective, twenty cohorts.

Linked-panel classification	March retrospective classification			
	Not a teacher	Stayed	Left	Total
Stayer (teaches all 4 post months)	198	7,911	67	8,176
Leaver (teaches in none)	1,018	10	257	1,285
Total	1,216	7,921	324	9,461

Teachers stable across all four initial monthly interviews, observed in all four follow-ups, window including March, linked to the following ASEC (n = 9,461). “Not a teacher”: the retrospective codes the longest job of the base year outside K–12 teaching.

Wherever the two instruments agree the person was a base-year teacher, they almost never disagree about what happened next: **99.1 percent** agreement, 77 true conflicts in 9,461 cases, stable at 98–100 percent in every cohort. The entire distance between the panel’s apparent attrition (13.6 percent among these stable teachers) and the retrospective’s (3.9 percent) lives in the 13 percent of panel-teachers whom the retrospective does not count as teachers at all—and their longest jobs are teaching assistant, other-instructor, education administrator, postsecondary teacher, childcare: the education-adjacent boundary, plus reference-week noise (summer non-employment, temporary absences) that a single-week snapshot cannot avoid. The panel measures leaving the *classroom this week*; the retrospective measures leaving the *profession this year*. For this paper’s questions the second is the estimand, and the audit shows it is measured consistently—which is also why the raw point-in-time panel rates that circulate in policy debates (15 percent and above) should not be read as profession exit.

Appendix B. Harris and Adams (2007) on the modern decades

Their design, applied verbatim to 2015–2024, returns their world with minor drift: teaching within half a point of its 1990s level, still indistinguishable from nursing once composition is controlled (the teacher–nurse gap ranges from +0.3 to –1.8 points across control sets), still five-plus points below social work. Teaching’s labor-force exit share—59 percent of attrition then, 62 now—and its outsized pension coefficient (–3.6 percentage points, versus –1.1 to –1.6 in the comparison professions) both survive. A literature that has spent two decades relitigating whether teacher attrition is exceptional can treat the question

Table 4: Leaving the profession, by type: 1992–2001 versus 2015–2024.

	Harris & Adams, 1992–2001				This paper, 2015–2024			
	All	Switch	Unemp.	Out LF	All	Switch	Unemp.	Out LF
Teachers	7.73	2.59	0.61	4.53	8.25	2.12	1.00	5.12
Nurses	6.09	1.68	0.86	3.54	7.99	3.66	0.81	3.53
Social workers	14.94	10.87	1.34	2.73	13.55	9.45	1.22	2.89
Accountants	8.01	4.10	1.55	2.36	6.30	1.79	1.18	3.32

Annual rates in percent, college graduates, March CPS. 1992–2001 from Harris and Adams (2007, Tables 1–2); 2015–2024 computed here. “Switch”: employed in another occupation; “Out LF”: out of the labor force in the survey week.

as closed: it was not then, and it is not now. What this paper adds is everything the level conceals.

Appendix C. Additional estimation output

Table 5: Annual attrition series, 2005–2024.

Calendar year	College graduates	All teachers	Observations	Weighted
2005	—	8.5%	4,161	no
2006	—	8.4%	4,336	no
2007	—	8.1%	4,357	no
2008	—	7.5%	4,448	no
2009	—	8.2%	4,357	no
2010	9.1%	11.2%	4,301	yes
2011	8.9%	11.5%	4,184	yes
2012	10.0%	12.5%	4,192	yes
2013	9.1%	11.7%	2,896	yes
2014	8.3%	9.8%	4,333	yes
2015	7.3%	9.2%	3,972	yes
2016	8.7%	10.7%	4,045	yes
2017	8.3%	10.4%	4,053	yes
2018	7.5%	9.7%	3,986	yes
2019	10.2%	12.3%	3,321	yes
2020	9.0%	11.4%	3,232	yes
2021	7.1%	8.8%	3,040	yes
2022	8.3%	10.1%	3,141	yes
2023	8.2%	9.6%	3,006	yes
2024	7.7%	10.3%	2,918	yes

College-graduate and all-teacher definitions. The 2005–2009 supplements support only the minimal extraction (occupation pairs); their rates are unweighted and shown for the trend only. The 2013 row uses the reduced five-eighths 2014 file.

Table 6: Determinants of leaving teaching: full probit.

	AME (pp)	SE
Age (per year)	-0.72	(0.07)
age2	0.01	(0.00)
Female	-1.41	(0.34)
Black	1.87	(0.49)
Married	-0.40	(0.43)
Separated or divorced	0.83	(0.58)
Master's degree or higher	-0.86	(0.30)
Public school	-1.72	(0.32)
Enrolled in a pension plan	-2.44	(0.32)
Part-time (<35 h/week)	4.47	(0.37)
Worked full year (50+ weeks)	-9.31	(0.32)
Number of children	-0.53	(0.17)
Child under 6	0.53	(0.51)
New baby during the year	4.67	(0.78)

Average marginal effects, percentage points; college-graduate teachers pooled 2015–2024 with survey-year fixed effects. Children variables from household parent and spouse pointers.

Table 7: Destination occupations of switchers.

Destination occupation	Share of switchers
Managers, all other	6.0%
Postsecondary teachers	4.9%
Education and childcare administrators	4.2%
Lawyers	3.7%
Postsecondary teachers	3.6%
Tutors	2.6%
Teaching assistants	2.6%
Teaching assistants	2.3%
Childcare workers	2.3%
Customer service representatives	2.1%
Secretaries and administrative assistants, except legal, medical, and executive	1.7%
Retail salespersons	1.3%

Detailed destination occupations among leavers employed at $t+1$, pooled 2015–2024; 19.5 percent of switchers remain in education occupations.